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Source: *Journal of Occupational Behaviour*, Vol. 1, No. 2 (Apr., 1980), pp. 151-157

Published by: Wiley

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/3000063>

Accessed: 03-08-2017 19:13 UTC

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Action research: theory, practice, and values

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SUMMARY

Action research enables social science to discharge its dual responsibility of contributing to scientific discovery and the solution of practical problems. The paper describes how social scientists can do this by adopting professional-collaborative roles with a set of interested parties to design and conduct a cycle of field experiments. The values of action research are humanistic, democratic and scientific, and its major concepts are from field and systems theory. Finally, an example of a typical collaborative engagement illustrates the theory, practice, values and outcomes of action research.

INTRODUCTION

A justification of action research

The traditional primary task of the university is the disinterested pursuit of knowledge. Unlike the physical and biological sciences, however, the social sciences cannot be indifferent to their objects of study. People, both individually and collectively, will reject social science, and deny access to critical settings unless they see some overlap of purpose or interest between themselves and social scientists. Data raids are too clearly one-sided and instrumental; they are unlikely to be tolerated for long, other than in trivial areas.

Social science, from this starting point, has a dual responsibility. It must contribute to the mutual enrichment of the key practical affairs of men, as well as to social science knowledge.

This argument does not deny a role for pure research which is seen as an essential complementary activity to action research. The point is that many central areas of social science can be advanced only by actively engaging with groups and activities outside the university. This may be done through applied research which brings previously established knowledge to bear on a practical problem. While it often has led to new knowledge, this is not its intended function. Another responsibility is to adopt the role of critic. This courts the danger of being based on inadequate knowledge and of raising the resistance of those people who have to carry the burden of responsibility. Yet another possibility is political activism. This loses the advantage of being a professional drawing on an established body of knowledge, using systematic methods and operating in terms of a code of ethics. The word of the social-scientist-as-activist is given no greater credibility than that of any other participant in the political arena. The role of advocate has similar disadvantages.

Action research (Clark, 1972; Clark, 1976) is suggested as an approach which

cope with many of these problems and yet enables social science to discharge its dual responsibility. Action research sets out both to make scientific discoveries and to solve practical problems. It does this by acquiring, testing and using knowledge as part of a single process. It avoids the delay between discovery and application, usually fifteen years or so, or the more extreme case in which applications never follow discovery. It also avoids the difficulty that theories and findings rarely fit particular situations. In the process of action research the social scientist adopts a professional-collaborative role with interested parties. This is because the action research approach depends on field experiments that are planned, conducted and evaluated by an extended set of interested parties rather than simply the social scientist. The set may include the 'subjects', administrators, and other power groups such as unions, employers and government. In this way the field experiments become relevant to a shared problem.

The approach also creates the opportunity to study social systems as they react to experimental manipulation. This is a powerful means of continuously arriving at valid knowledge and applying the insights to the solution of human, organizational and societal problems. In this way also the social system is provided with a means of turning itself into a learning system that can adapt to changing circumstances by taking an active role in shaping its own future.

The elements of action research are an explicit set of values, concepts and methods that together make up a theory of research and practice. It is a theory, as I said earlier, about how to acquire, test and use knowledge.

VALUES

The values of action research are humanistic, democratic and scientific. Humanistic in the sense that there is a commitment to the dignity and worth of the individual human being. Democratic in the sense that each individual or group is seen as being entitled to a say in decisions that affect him. This protects him from the tyranny of superiors and experts. Both parties take their place as members of a cast of actors not as stars: their contributions go into the shared decision-making mill along with those of other interested parties. Scientific in the sense that assumptions are made explicit and that propositions are stated clearly and tested against systematically collected and public evidence. Further that there is an openness in attitude so that theories are changed when they are inconsistent with the evidence. As Leonardo da Vinci said, 'Those sciences that are not born of experience and that do not end in experience are vain and full of errors'. These values are opposite to those that Argyris and Schon (1974) have summarized as the values governing the predominant theory-in-use in professional behaviour: achieve your own purpose as defined by yourself; win, do not lose; suppress negative feelings; be rational. These values lead to unilateral decision-making and monopolization of tasks. This provides little opportunity for new learning by other actors. The social scientists come to be seen as manipulative and the other actors become defensive and do not commit themselves to action. Argyris and Schon go on to point to the gap between this model, Model I, that most people use and the Model II that they claim they use.

The governing values of the espoused model are: maximize valid information, maximize freedom of choice, enhance internal commitment to choices made, and monitor consequences of these decisions. This model, of course, is close to the one being put forward as underlying action research. It, too, would be required to live up to this claim. For instance can a particular interested person or group refuse to play the action research game when peers or superiors want to play it?

CONCEPTS

The concepts of action research derive from the work of the main centres responsible for pioneering it over the last twenty-five or thirty years. These are the Research Centres for Group Dynamics in the University of Michigan and the Tavistock Institute of Human Relations in London. The concepts are those of open systems theory. They point towards the extension of a field of study rather than its limitation; they approach problems contextually rather than abstracting aspects radically and early in a study.

The thinking relies heavily on the concept of interdependence between parts of a system and its environment (Emery, 1969). The broadest analysis involves the specification of the inputs to a system (men, materials, money, information) the transformation they undergo, the outputs that come out of the system, and the feedback loops that are used to keep the system in a state of quasi-equilibrium.

Sutherland (1973) considers that the major assumptions are:

- (1) that systems tend to differentiate into parts with particular functions;
- (2) that analysis should precede from whole to a part rather than from part to whole. As Lewin (1951) said, 'Observation of social behaviour is of little value if it doesn't include an adequate description of the larger unit of behaviour within which the social act occurs';
- (3) that the behaviour of systems that resist internal analysis or attempts to make them internally deterministic may well turn out to be deterministic at a macro-level—the phenomenon of macro-determinancy.

An important advantage of systems theory is that it keeps the total organization and its environment in focus, including its economic, technological, social and political aspects. At the same time it takes account of both structure and process rather than the more common pattern of concentrating on one of these to the neglect of the other.

METHOD

Turning to method: as I said earlier, action research depends heavily on developing collaborative relations with interested parties; Chevalier (1968) calls this interest group planning. The required professional collaborative role is characterized by:

- (1) The provision of a service to the total system rather than any part of it, for instance, management or worker.

- (2) A preparedness to confront issues and parties when it is necessary for the welfare of the total system.
- (3) A concern to bring groups together so that they can explore the nature and degree of their conflict and consensus.
- (4) An emphasis on getting sanction for the values, concepts and method of action research, including the dissemination of findings, and the following cycle of events: a first appreciation of a situation, theory building, design of a study, preferably including before-and-after measures, an introduction of experimental changes, and an evaluation of the intended and unintended consequences.

Then repeated cycling through these stages, starting with a second appreciation, modification of theory, a second design stage, further experimental manipulation of variables and evaluation of their consequences. While Lewin (1947) pioneered this strategy, Campbell (1963, 1968) has more recently been extremely influential in championing field studies and the idea of reforms as experiments. He has also provided quasi-experimental designs for interpreting results.

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE STUDY

I will now briefly illustrate the values, concepts, methods and stages by describing a typical engagement. At the same time we can get a feel for the sort of learning that is taking place as participants become involved in the process of action research. Despite the drive towards being explicit about the process, much of the learning takes place through osmosis rather than explicit and didactic teaching—it is valid experimental learning that combines theory and practice in a real-life situation. In this particular manufacturing company, employing about 1,000 people, the presenting problem was poor industrial relations, over 100 per cent labour turnover, 50 per cent wastage of material and low production. A first agreement was obtained from management and unions that the action research approach was an appropriate means of tackling these problems and of bringing about organizational changes that would prevent their reappearing.

A first appreciation of the situation showed that departments were operating as independent units, that there were severe conflicts between various levels of management and between management and workers, and that there was no effective mechanism for locating where errors were occurring in the manufacturing process.

The collaborative relationship was extended by establishing: (1) a steering committee with representatives from every department and level; (2) a more localized committee in the finishing factory which was chosen as the focal department for the study; and, (3) small working parties, one on labour turnover and one on team-working.

A theoretical model was developed, mainly as an input from the social science team but with agreement from organizational collaborators that it appeared to fit the realities of this particular situation. It was based on socio-technical theory,

including the control of variance and semi-autonomous work groups and reference group and intergroup theory (Davis and Cherns, 1975).

Studies were then designed on the basis of the theoretical model; as data were gathered experimental changes were introduced. For instance, work teams were created to span interdependencies among the various processes involved in preparing the material and manufacturing it into the final product. The first team on the manufacturing line had a representative on it from the materials supply department. His job was to reflect the views of the team back to his own section, particularly about how well the material they were supplying was holding up. The first team also had a representative on it from the second team. This prevented faulty products being passed onto the second team, particularly as the teams were made responsible for their own quality control. Payment was linked to within-tolerance work both in the particular work team and in the overall production line. This meant that there was less advantage in transporting mistakes from one team to the next. This overlapping strategy was developed throughout the factory.

The work teams met weekly, kept records of their progress and made suggestions for improvement. A constant re-evaluation of the effects of the various experimental changes was maintained. For instance some work teams seemed to require tighter supervision than had first been envisaged. As this became apparent, tighter supervision was re-introduced.

Communication channels were established between the teams, the working parties, the finishing factory committee and the steering committee. In this way the various departments, managerial levels, union representatives and individual workers were brought together and came closer to working as an integrated whole. Long-standing conflicts, often determined by structural arrangements, were uncovered and gradually worked through in the context of the shared task of introducing experimental changes. As the programme developed, it slowly reduced the impact of the disjunctions between purchasing, stores, work-scheduling, systems control, payment, inspection, supervision, sales, not to mention personnel and production, and various levels of management. The overall system began to run as a totality rather than separate sub-systems.

Attention was also paid to the character of the external environment. The committees monitored new inputs and developed policies to cope with them. The changes included increased prices for raw materials, as world markets fluctuated, variations in orders because of conditions in associated industries, reduction in the supply of local labour as other employers brought new opportunities to the locality, and policy decisions from group level.

People at all levels had to cope with a massive injection of social science knowledge, a demand to adopt a scientific attitude, threats to their prerogatives, a new collaborative relationship with other people, confrontations with people they could usually avoid, exposure of vested interests, and revealing of information they usually kept secret.

The acquisition of new skills was difficult for many people used to a less participative process, but most of them slowly and often painfully, came to appreciate the advantages of collaboration and social support offered by a team rather than an individual method of working. It became apparent, however, that this type of programme required much more systematic attention to training in

new skills than was given. This held for all levels of management, as well as for people on the shop floor.

Nonetheless action research did contribute to the development of the following skills: a liberal outlook, that accepts opposing views, an appreciation of the distribution of power and the need for collaborative processes, the acquisition of scientific attitude that view administration as experimentation to bring about desired results, and an appreciation of the advantages of open systems theory. The example also illustrates the characteristics of the professional-collaborative role. A service based on social science knowledge was introduced into the system at all levels. The action researchers talked about theory and method with all parties. This input was corrected against the experience and knowledge of the participants. Confrontation occurred, for instance, about managerial pressure for production that ignored the available skills and equipment and about the dominance of the systems people with their computer control of scheduling of work and recording of output. In terms of the welfare of the total system, managers and system analysts were confronted with the need to see their actions in relation to those of people in other sub-systems. The adherence to systems theory highlighted the disjunction between management and worker, between departments and between levels. The collaborative approach brought the conflicting parties together to resolve the issues or, at least, to contain the most damaging outcomes. It also revealed instances in which people were exposed to conflicting demands, for example, from their immediate superior and another superior or peer. The case study also shows the importance of gaining and maintaining the sanction of the different parties so that the cycle of events could be completed. Had the management or union withdrawn sanction for group working, the experiments would not have been possible.

In all a great deal of new knowledge was obtained about socio-technical systems and their links into economic and power systems. For instance it was found that relatively large work groups could be effective with a technology and physical lay-out that looked completely inappropriate. New power groups were located, for example, the systems analysts, and the consequences traced through to interdependent sub-systems. Access was gained to board meetings and it was then possible to see the cascading effects of power conflicts at that level flowing down the system. It also made it possible to understand mysterious shifts in attitude and coalition. These processes provided perfect examples of balance theory in action. The role of the mediator between the social scientist and organizational members was uncovered. In this programme the personnel manager performed this role, often putting himself in a perilous position because he was seen as being too close to the social scientists. On the economic side, the apparent economy of keeping stocks low was shown to lead to expensive unintended consequences, such as large stockpiles of partly finished products waiting for terminals. Important knowledge was gained about the impact of environmental inputs. The material reinforced Trist's (1976) emphasis on organizational ecology and provided an opportunity to move to a first approximation of the important theoretical units. At a general methodological level, working collaboratively with a wide range of people kept the study close to the data. This enhanced the chances of developing grounded theory (Glaser and Strauss, 1967).

CONCLUSION

Action research emerges as an approach that may be useful in helping social science discharge its responsibility to society. It preserves the best aspects and values of the scientific model, while at the same time being tuned to real life situations, appreciating their uncertainties, complexities and dynamic properties. Further by stressing the interdependence between systems and sub-systems that are often treated as being independent of one another, it reveals new functional relationships.

Its marginal nature allows it to move in the middle ground between pure and applied research. This allows a cross-fertilization between these usually separate activities. In addition, it makes sense to the external world. It is not too exclusively theoretical nor too practical; and it allows the social scientist to contribute directly to policy formation, planning, and implementation, with an emphasis on a normative base and continuous learning.

It may provide a path to the goal that all social administration should be conducted as experimentation to bring about a desired state of affairs. It restores the lost unity of thinking and doing, researching and action.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

I would like to acknowledge the contributions that Michael Foster, David Pledger, Estelle Kebac and my wife Nicola made to the action research engagement described in this paper.

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